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- Published: 2026-05-26
- Original: <https://www.bleepingcomputer.com/news/security/knowledgedeliver-flaw-exploited-as-a-zero-day-to-install-web-shells/>
- Preserved from: <https://www.bleepingcomputer.com/news/security/knowledgedeliver-flaw-exploited-as-a-zero-day-to-install-web-shells/> (preserved-copy) on 2026-08-04
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KnowledgeDeliver flaw exploited as a zero-day to install web shells

By

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- May 26, 2026
- 04:07 PM



Hackers exploited a critical zero-day vulnerability in a server running the KnowledgeDeliver learning management system (LMS) to deploy the Godzilla web shell.

The flaw is a deserialization issue tracked as [CVE-2026-5426](#) and can be exploited without authentication. It stems from the use of a shared hardcoded machine key in the web portal configuration across all KnowledgeDeliver customer deployments.

ViewState deserialization

Threat actors obtained the machine key and used it in ViewState deserialization attacks to sign malicious ViewState payloads and achieve remote code execution at the operating system level.

AI Threat Readiness for the Enterprise: Defending at Machine Speed		
Weaponized AI or Machine Speed Threats		
Weaponized Input Window As agents autonomously expand access to external data and devices, they also expand the attack surface.	The "One Head" Single models receive high volumes of design, engineering, and data, rapidly to networks.	Chained exploits Attacks use AI to complete multi-step, high-complexity tasks across complex systems.
Expanding Attack Surface with AI use/adoption		
Machine AI & Data Loading Agents autonomously access confidential data and code.	Adversarial Code Attackers use AI to generate code that evades security.	Infrastructure Misconfiguration AI.
Why It Matters		
1 Speed (or lack thereof) is the threat. Vulnerability discovery rates are exploding as models autonomously exploit vulnerabilities in hours, not weeks, making chained zero-day flows the new normal.		
2 The Human Gap: Traditional AppSec is obsolete. You simply cannot defend against continuous, machine-speed attacks with manual, human-speed operations and patching cycles.		
3 Machine speed Defense: The only way to survive is to achieve a dynamic, integrated defense that can fix code velocity as fast as attackers break it. Continuous resilience is the race.		

Mandiant in late 2025 responded to an attack on a KnowledgeDeliver server and says that initially, the vulnerability was exploited as a zero-day to inject a malicious script into the web platform.

Exploitation was possible due to the use of “identical pre-shared ASP.NET machine keys across multiple customer deployments,” the researchers said.

“KnowledgeDeliver installations deployed before Feb. 24, 2026 relied on a standardized web.config file provided by the vendor. This configuration file contained hardcoded machineKey values used by the ASP.NET framework to encrypt and sign data, including ViewState payloads,” Mandiant explains.

According to the researchers, the malicious code on the platform “convinced users to download a fake installer,” which led to the machine getting infected with a Cobalt Strike beacon, essentially planting a backdoor.

“The payload was encrypted using a key that used the name of the compromised organization, which indicated that the threat actor prepared this payload specifically for the targeted organization,” [Mandiant says](#) in a report today.

Godzilla web shell delivery

Mandiant says the threat actor deployed the .NET-based in-memory web shell, Godzilla (a.k.a. BlueBeam), which has also been used in [similar attacks observed by Microsoft](#) in late 2024.

In August 2024, researchers at cybersecurity company ASEC had also [reported](#) that Godzilla was being deployed in ASP.NET environments in ViewState deserialization attacks targeting companies in the financial sector.

Mandiant notes that the threat actor compromising KnowledgeDeliver instances executed commands to escalate their control over the web server's file system.

This allowed them to modify an application JavaScript file with code that prompted users to install a “security authentication plugin” and to load a malicious script from a domain under the attacker’s control.

Over the past year, hackers have used improperly secured machine keys in ViewState deserialization attacks targeting web platforms for various products.

In March last year, threat actors [abused a hardcoded machine key](#) to craft a malicious payload that allowed access to Gladinet CentreStack's secure file-sharing servers.

In July 2025, hackers [compromised 85 Microsoft SharePoint servers](#) after stealing the machine key to create signed malicious ViewState payloads.

State-sponsored actors also used ViewState deserialization attacks to deploy a reconnaissance tool named [WeepSteel on Sitecore servers](#) that exposed the ASP.NET machine key.



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